

Safdie comes to Boston: ARCHITECTURE

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Moshe Safdie is an architect famous the world over for something he did more than a decade ago, which was to create, as part of Expo '67 in Montreal, an incredible pyramid of dwellings called "Habitat."

Now Safdie has moved to Boston, where he has relocated his main office and taken up the position of director of the Urban Design Program at the Harvard Graduate School of Design.

Appropriately for an urbanist, Safdie's office is in Faneuil Hall Markets. There are branch offices in Jerusalem and Baltimore, and both are likely to be busy. After a slump in the years following Habitat, Safdie's practice has expanded to an international scale, and he spends his time caroming by jet between Montreal, the locus of his office for 14 years despite the fact that he never gets any work in Canada; Jerusalem, where Safdie has what appears to be much of the city under reconstruction; Baltimore, where his new community, Coldspring, is being built; Senegal in Africa, site of another new Safdie city; Iran, and now Boston.

In an interview, Safdie, who is still only 40, spoke of some of the concerns that led him to accept the Harvard post held for many years by Willo von Moltke, who retired last year.

ARCHITECTURE By ROBERT CAMPBELL

"I haven't taught much in recent years," Safdie said, "but I am concerned about the influence in the design schools of certain architects, especially the New York Five and their followers. I think their ideas are dangerous, unhealthy. It's inner circle design, it's irresponsible."

The New York Five is a group of architects who have exhibited together and often lecture at design schools. Though very different from one another, all share the idea that the so-called "modern movement" with its relative severity is changing, that architects should now feel free to play around with shapes and ideas drawn from history or merely from their own imaginations.

In this connection, Safdie refers to the controversy over the proposed new American Telephone and Telegraph headquarters in New York City, a 50-story corporate logo resembling a piece of Chippen-dale furniture. He quotes a letter he sent to its architect, Philip Johnson:

"This formalistic visual game in which there are no rules is motivated sometimes by whim, humor or the desire to shock,

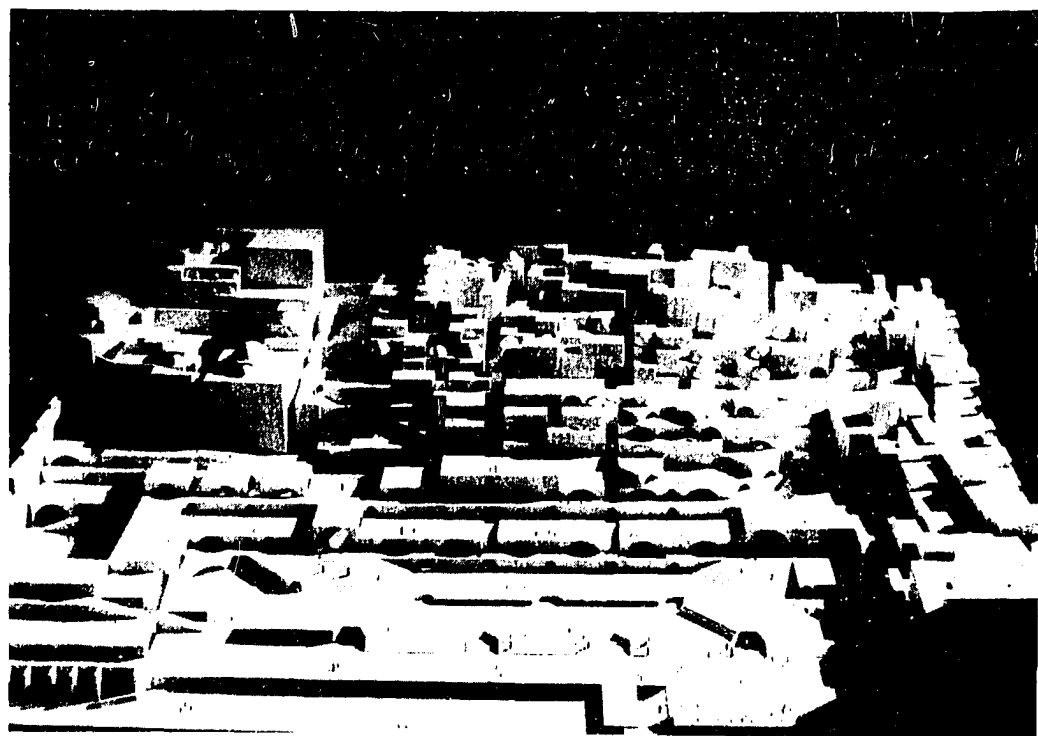
and sometimes by boredom or nostalgia." Safdie shares Johnson's feeling that modernism failed, but thinks the answer isn't cleverness but rather is a serious response to social and psychological needs and to new construction methods. Safdie thinks the best source of design inspiration is the "architecture without architects," the villages built all over the world by nameless peasants and nomads. In his first lecture at Harvard he contrasted the bad architecture done by the government housing office in Jerusalem with the richer, more humane refugee villages nearby, built from scrap by illiterates. He even praised Gothic architecture for being "more honest" than the work of such later figures as Michelangelo. He attacked not only artists, but the whole idea of art, saying it is preoccupied with personal expression and with "authorship."

"When we see art, it's always in environments that are bad, Picasso in the civic center or on the executive's wall," Safdie told his audience. A well built world would need no art because it would consist of nothing else.

Safdie feels that Habitat, where he lived for years, has worn well. He says it combined two ideas, one social, the other technical. The social idea was to create a place as densely peopled as any city yet with the amenities of the suburbs — "For Everyone A Garden," as the title of one of his books says. The technical idea was to build it of factory-fabricated parts. Safdie admits he's had to learn, in the years since, to separate these two ideas, since the social has proved far more achievable.

At Harvard, Safdie will be taking over a program that has been through many changes. In the '60s, Harvard Urban Design Students tended to plan grandly, creating Flash Gordon cities in the sky. In the '70s they've concentrated on small scale, realistic projects, often working closely with actual planners in such efforts as redevelopment studies for East Cambridge, Fort Point Channel and Broad street in downtown Boston.

Safdie wants to return part way to the big scale work. "There's been too much small, piecemeal replanning," he says. He admits no one is likely to build big in America, but points out that more than half his students are foreign and that many of those who do stay in the US will work on overseas projects in growing na-



Model shows Safdie scheme for sacred Western Wall in the Old City of Jerusalem. (Wall itself is not visible off bottom of photo.) Safdie would excavate down to bottom of the Wall, built at the time of Herod, then terrace back up to the present city, filling terraces with new buildings mixed with archeological remains.

tions where large scale design is still happening.

Safdie is impressive in that he has grappled, successfully or not, with just about the whole range of design. He has written books and planned cities. He has designed not only buildings but the parts they will be made of, and also the factories to make those parts.

He's interested in suburbs, in politics, in social theory. In Jerusalem, where his most interesting work has been designed and is beginning to be built, Safdie, who was born in Israel, has taken on without trepidation the redesign of nothing less than the sacred Western Wall (Wailing Wall) itself. Safdie proposes to excavate the Wall to its 2000-year-old base, doubling its present height. From the excavation will be created an amphitheater that will terrace back from the Wall up to the level of the present city. Each terrace will represent the ground level of Jerusalem at a particular period in its history and will contain remains of that time.

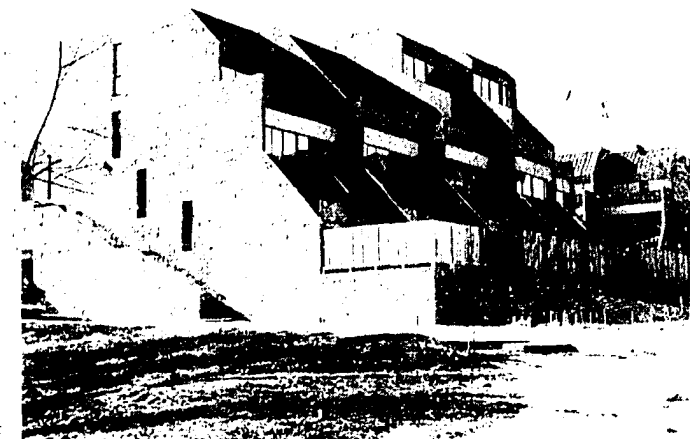
There will be new housing and public buildings done by Safdie in a contemporary manner that nevertheless incorporates arches and domes. Nearby, mean-

while, a new Yeshiva, also by Safdie is near completion.

At a moment when architecture and urban design are practically being torn apart by trendiness, Safdie's single-minded pursuit of ideals that haven't changed much since Habitat comes as something of a surprise. He says one reason he chose to locate in Boston, instead of New York, is that he wanted to maintain a certain

distance from the current center of innovation.

That's often been Boston's role, and it will be interesting to see how he does here.



Coldspring New Town, Baltimore, is an inner city redevelopment designed to lure middle classes back to the city. Heavy subsidies permit novel housing at low cost. Safdie calls it an effort to achieve dense, communal feeling of his Habitat in Montreal, but with conventional construction.